

EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE ACTIVITIES FOR KIDS

Empathy, Social Skills & Gratitude Practices

By Daniel Tesfamariam

WHAT IS EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE?

EQ (Emotional Quotient) matters MORE than IQ for life success.

5 components of EQ:

- Self-awareness: Knowing what I feel
- Self-regulation: Managing my reactions
- Motivation: Pushing through hard things
- Empathy: Understanding how others feel
- Social skills: Getting along with people

The good news: EQ can be TAUGHT and practiced like any skill!

SELF-AWARENESS ACTIVITIES

1. Feelings Check-In (Daily)

Right now I feel: _____ because _____

My body feels: _____

What I need: _____

2. Emotions Charades

Take turns acting out emotions. Others guess the feeling.

Emotions: happy, sad, angry, scared, surprised, disgusted, nervous, excited, embarrassed, proud, jealous, grateful

3. Body Map

Where do you feel emotions in your body?

Anger = _____ (hot face? tight fists? fast heart?)

Sadness = _____ (heavy chest? stinging eyes? tired body?)

Anxiety = _____ (butterflies? sweaty palms? racing thoughts?)

Joy = _____ (light body? big smile? warm chest?)

EMPATHY BUILDERS

1. Perspective Flip

When reading a book or watching a show, pause and ask:

'How do you think [character] feels? Why? What would YOU feel?'

2. Kindness Jar

Each family member writes acts of kindness they notice on slips.

Read them together weekly. Who can fill the jar?

3. Walk in Their Shoes

When a conflict happens, ask:

'Can you tell me what [person] might be thinking and feeling?'

'What might be going on in their life that we don't see?'

4. Community Helper Project

Choose one monthly: food bank, elderly visit, neighbor help, donation drive, thank-you cards for helpers (mail carrier, teacher)

SOCIAL SKILLS PRACTICE

Conversation Skills:

STARTING: 'Hi! I'm [name]. What are you playing?'

JOINING: 'Can I play too? What role can I have?'

LISTENING: Eye contact + nodding + asking questions

DISAGREEING: 'I see it differently. What if we try...'

APOLOGIZING: 'I'm sorry I [specific action]. Are you okay?'

Friendship Skills Checklist:

- ☐ I take turns in conversations
- ☐ I notice when someone looks sad or left out
- ☐ I can disagree without being mean
- ☐ I celebrate my friends' successes
- ☐ I apologize when I make a mistake
- ☐ I include others in my games
- ☐ I keep secrets that friends share with me
- ☐ I ask before borrowing things

GRATITUDE PRACTICES

1. Gratitude Journal (Nightly)

3 things I'm grateful for today:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Someone I'm grateful for: _____ Why: _____

2. Thank-You Note Writing

Once a week, write a thank-you note to someone specific.

Dear: _____

Thank you for: _____

It made me feel: _____

3. Rose, Thorn, Bud (Dinner Table Game)

Rose = best part of today: _____

Thorn = hardest part: _____

Bud = something to look forward to: _____

By Daniel Tesfamariam | EQ is the skill that makes all other skills work.